my whole career. The setting, the occasion and the privilege of being at the head of the line as captain of your country at a World Cup: my heart was beating out of my chest. It's a schoolboy's dream but it's the kind of dream you don't dare have. And here it was, happening. The atmosphere was terrific. One corner with a few thousand Sweden fans; the rest of the stadium red and white, our own supporters and the Japanese who'd decided to make England their team. Fractured metatarsal? So what? I could never have allowed myself to miss this.

Pity the game wasn't as intense as the build-up. We played well, especially early on, but somehow the game didn't feel like it could decide where it was going. There weren't many scoring chances. Where were the big tackles and the confrontations? You couldn't honestly say you saw it coming but, 25 minutes in, we got the first goal. I took a corner on the left and Sol Campbell arrived and got a perfect header in. Sol went running off towards the other corner flag to celebrate. I was just going mad on my own, as if it was me who'd scored. I turned round and put my arms up in the direction of the Swedish supporters, who'd been giving me plenty of grief. They were still laughing. Maybe they knew that their time would come.

Scoring's one thing. Setting a goal up for someone else is a fantastic feeling as well and, that night, I was so pleased it was Sol who got it. We go back fifteen years together, to training with Tottenham as schoolboys, and he doesn't score many. Against Argentina at France 98, in extra-time when we were down to ten men, he'd had one disallowed which, if it had stood, would probably have won us the game. Now, he'd kicked us off in 2002. The trouble was, we didn't push on from that. We were ahead but we were cautious, tense, sitting back on the lead. And then in the second half, we couldn't keep the ball. Our passing was all over the place. And Sweden kept on coming at us. Unlike our goal in the first half, you could see theirs was due. We just lost concentration, as a team, at the wrong moment and gifted them their equalizer. When a rushed clearance from Danny Mills was blasted into the net by Niclas Alexandersson, it would have been easy for people to blame Danny for the goal. I didn't think it was his fault. There were two or three other mistakes in the build-up as well. I made a point of getting near him.

'Come on, Danny. Let's keep going.'

A couple of minutes later, Sven took me off. It was my first game since Deportivo at Old Trafford and, to be honest, I was feeling it. The foot was sore but it was more about match fitness. Early in the second half, I'd been thinking: what's happened to my legs? I'm sure Sven could see me puffing a